

900–1100

# THE EARLY MIDDLE AGES

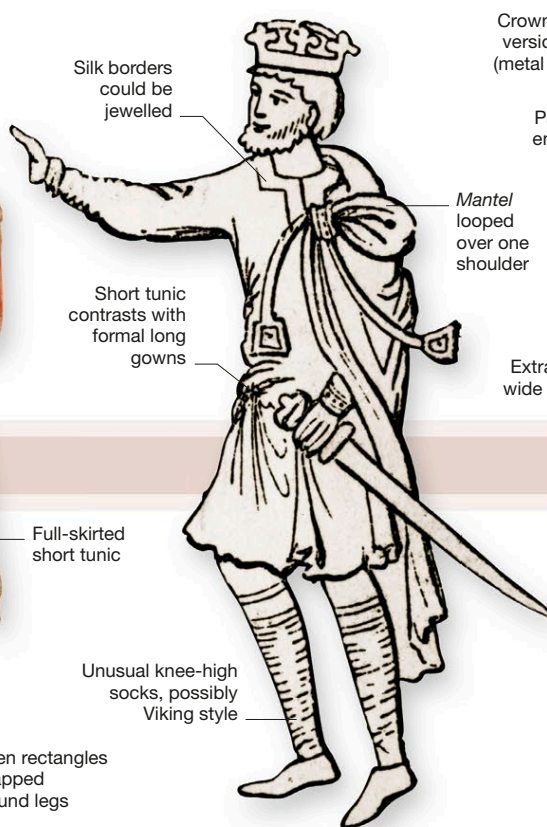
As people began to settle into stable societies, different styles of dress evolved. Charlemagne's Holy Roman Empire and the monasteries of Anglo-Saxon England recorded clothing details in illuminated manuscripts. The modern words "kirtle" (undertunic) and "mantle" (cloak) originated from the Anglo-Saxon *cyrtel* and *mantel*. Women wore a kirtle over a linen undergarment, and often an outer gown as well. There was still little difference between clerical and secular dress, all continuing to be based on Ancient Roman principles of draped rectangles. Southern areas around modern Spain and Italy particularly wanted to show links with the former empire in Romanesque style. Women covered their heads with veils according to Christian ideas of pious modesty. As textile technology improved, people used more fabric in their clothing. Eastern silk from as far as China outstripped local products in complexity and beauty, making it highly prized.



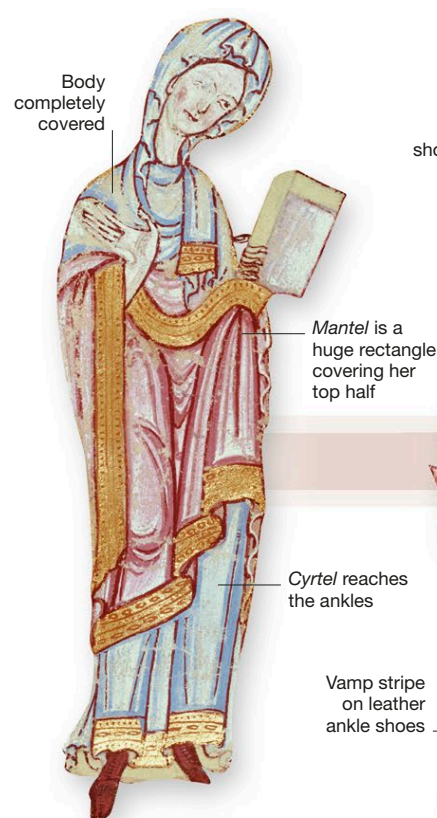
**Everyday wear** A linen veil is wrapped around this 11th-century woman's head. Her outer gown has short sleeves, and it covers a much fuller, longer tunic.



**Simple dress** In the 1020s this man has the keyhole neckline seen in noble dress, but in a plain fabric. His tunic is short and easy to move in, with tight cuffs.



**Anglo-Saxon king** More modest than continental rulers, Cnut of Wessex wears a silk-bordered tunic. A later Anglo-Saxon king's clothing was "interwoven with gold and sumptuously embellished".



**Anglo-Saxon cyrtel, mantel, and veil** In the 1060s Judith, Countess of Flanders, is shown draped with cloth. Her long, semicircular linen veil wraps over her head and shoulders. The *mantel* is draped sideways.



**Fit for a king** Biblical King David, in a manuscript of 1050, wears a long, dignified gown in quality fabric – the signs of a ruler – with a woven pattern and frilled hem. The gartering holding his braccas (trousers) is carefully interlaced.



**Anglo-Saxon queen** Noblewomen like Aelfgyfu-Emma, King Cnut's wife, enjoyed wearing sumptuous dress. Her clothing, c.1040, was probably dyed with costly colours.